



India's international assignments in 2024

January: ODI and three-match T20I series against Australia

September-October: T20 World Cup in Bangladesh

December: Three ODIs in Australia

December-January: Three ODIs and T20Is against the West Indies and Ireland

Source: Women's Future Tours Programme (2022-2025)

Damp squib: It was a disappointing start to Alyssa Healy's reign as captain, having been appointed Meg Lanning's successor across all formats in early December. EMMANUAL YOGINI

game," Sudha said, hoping these victories pave the way for longer format fixtures.

The Indian players would hope so too. Otherwise, the noteworthy achievements, such as Richa Ghosh's fifty on debut, Sneha's seven-wicket haul, and Jemimah Rodrigues' back-to-back fifties, might not contribute much to India's progress. Instead, they would merely be footnotes in the history of the game.

In recent years, the BCCI has reiterated its commitment to women's cricket. It has ensured pay parity between male and female cricketers, introduced the WPL, and, notably, scheduled four Tests for the team since 2021 — two at home and two away.

However, despite these initiatives, there is still much work to be done. Aligning with Mithali's suggestion, reinstating multi-day games at the domestic level, reminiscent of earlier times, would facilitate a smoother transition for players from white-ball cricket to Tests.

For seasoned campaigners like Sneha, the shift hasn't been a concern. "Earlier, our domestic tournaments were played with the red ball, so we

have that experience. White-ball came in much later. But for me, it's just about a change in the colour of the ball; everything else remains the same," Sneha said, adding, "It's a game of the mind."

It, indeed, is. The hundred or so spectators cheering for the home team at Wankhede Stadium witnessed an intense rivalry between captains Harmanpreet Kaur and Alyssa Healy. The match featured nervous moments, displays of attitude, and appeals for obstructing the field. "That's the beauty of Test cricket; it brings the best out of the players," said Richa, who made her debut against the Aussies.

The 20-year-old from Siliguri had to warm the bench for the game against England.

However, an injury to Shubha Sateesh opened doors for her. Her crucial partnership with Jemimah in the first innings brought India back into the game after Smriti Mandhana was run out.

"The fact that you have to take things session by session itself is a huge learning experience for India's youngsters. They seemed to be in no hurry to score runs, nor did they press the panic button when there were no breakthroughs. They handled things according to the situation. That was a very impressive thing," said Sudha.

The team, under new head coach Amol Muzumdar, had extended

preparation at the National Cricket Academy, including a multi-day side game, which reflected in its organised performance under Harmanpreet's leadership.

While the result was undoubtedly gratifying, the broader question revolves around whether India intends to increase the number of Tests in its schedule. Does it have the necessary time and capacity? The players and visiting teams maintain an optimistic outlook.

"We would love to see more and more Tests, and I think it would create a real contest over three games. But the nature of the female game at the moment is that it's very white-ball dominant, and trying to fit it all into the calendar, and fit all the white-ball games in particular, seems to take precedence. You take three one-day games out, and we could probably play two more Test matches," stated Australia captain Healy.

She, surely, would have the support of the Indian players. Ahead of the Test against England, Mandhana had wished to be part of the World Test Championship someday.

And the two wins against England and Australia would only bolster her hopes of Tests gaining more dominance in women's cricket in the near future.